

Sex abuse suspect charged in fraud case

By STEWART AIN

Mordechai Ehrman, the Brooklyn man under investigation in connection with a series of sex attacks on young children at an Orthodox play group operated by his wife, was arrested last week and charged with filing false state applications for food stamps.

Ehrman, 49, of East 5th Street in the New Utrecht section of Brooklyn, pleaded not guilty before Brooklyn Supreme Court Justice Michael Curci, who ordered Ehrman held without bail. He was released in his own custody the next day.

Ehrman is alleged to have received in excess of \$3,000 in food stamps to which he was not entitled. He could be sent to prison for 2 1/3 to seven years.

A former bus driver for his wife's Simcha Play Group in Flatbush, Ehrman was ordered late last year to stay away from the group by a *bais din* (Jewish court). A second *bais din* convened early this year concluded after a four-month probe that there are "sufficient grounds" to believe the sex abuse charges against him.

Ehrman, an Orthodox Jew who is said to have attended the respected Bobov Yeshiva, a chasidic institution, has denied the allegations. A woman at his home said he would

not speak with the press.

The office of Brooklyn District Attorney Charles Hynes issued a press release announcing the 13-count fraud indictment, but it made no mention of the office's continuing sex abuse investigation. Five days later, Hynes' office reportedly placed Ehrman in a lineup before two youngsters he had allegedly sexually abused three years ago.

A family friend of the youngsters who asked not to be identified told The Jewish Week that neither boy was able to recognize anyone in the lineup. She blamed that on Hynes' office.

"I'm surprised they didn't have them [those in the lineup] wear a mask," she said bitterly.

She explained that the boys, 6 and 7, viewed the lineup separately and that the five or six bearded men they viewed were seated, had numbers beneath their beards and were wearing a hat.

"All the boys could see was the number, the beard and the hat," she complained. "When the boys asked that the men take off their hats because they never saw Ehrman with a hat, they were told the hats had to stay because some of the men in the lineup were bald or had thinning hair, and Ehrman has a full head of hair.

"It all seems like a masquerade," she added. "They gave us a bone

with the [fraud indictment] and figured that would shut us up.

"Many of us had felt that the district attorney wanted us to disappear, but the parents of the older boy pressed on, saying they believed he [the DA] was serious and compassionate. But they told me they saw relief in the face of the prosecutors after the kids failed to pick anyone out of the lineup."

The older boy's parents want a new lineup "without the masquerade," said the woman. And she said members of the community want the district attorney to have a lineup for other youngsters who contend they too were sexually abused. She said Hynes' office has interviewed about 70 of these youngsters, and that the sexual abuse occurred over a period of five or six years to "hundreds" of children aged 2 through 4.

A spokesman for Hynes' office has declined all comment.

The friend of the family said she believes Hynes is dragging his feet in the case because of leaders in the Jewish community — including prominent rabbis.

"They have an in with the district attorney's office and hold weight as to whether a case is pressed or not," she said. "They want this one shoved under the carpet. A sex abuse case in the Jewish community is not going to give the district attorney fame and glory and so it is going to be hushed up."